MEMORANDUM

To:	**Dr. Jason Tham**
From:	**Doctoral Student Richard Dixon Riddle**
Date:	**October 27, 2026**
Subject:	**Web Portfolio Draft: Platform Justification & AI Use Statement**

Overview

My portfolio draft is live at prof-richriddle.github.io/portfolio. It is called "What Are We Doing Here? A Portfolio Guide for Various Folk in My Life," and it is built for a mixed crowd: friends and family, co-authors and peers, and professors. It is not built for hiring managers.

The site has five pages:

- **Home:** three big buttons, one for each kind of visitor.
- **About Me (Life & Teaching):** my bio, how I work, the classes I teach, four class activities, and the dogs.
- **Friends & Family:** how one class proposal became a conference talk and then a book chapter, what each doctoral stage means, and a timeline of where I am now.
- **Portfolio (Research & Writing):** major work, three writing samples with narratives, coursework summaries, and certifications. Visitors sort by type and filter by topic.
- **Read Me:** how the site works, why I chose GitHub Pages, and my AI use.

The draft is more than 85% complete. Three Read Me sections are placeholders marked "Coming soon": what changed after user testing, the WAVE accessibility check, and the AI-ready or AI-resilient redesign. All three come with the final version.

Platform Justification

I built the portfolio on GitHub Pages with Jekyll, GitHub's built-in publishing system, instead of a website builder like Wix or Google Sites. The assignment allows either, and three reasons decided it for me:

1. **Each piece of work is its own small text file.** The portfolio holds 35 entries. To fix a typo or add a paper, I edit one file, and the site rebuilds itself. In a builder, I would be dragging and re-styling 35 boxes by hand.
2. **The design is kept separate from the content.** One stylesheet controls the look of every page, so changing the colors or the tile layout never touches the writing.
3. **It is free, with no ads or platform branding, and I own every file.** I want a site I can keep growing after this class, not one tied to a subscription.

There was a tradeoff. My static page was one HTML file I typed myself; this site has layouts, collections, and a script for the filters, which is more than I could build alone at this point in the course. I tested whether it was the right call by asking myself one question: can I still change it? The answer has been yes. I can open a single file on GitHub, change a word, select “Commit changes,” and see it live a minute later.

The platform also serves the criterion on hypermedia and multimodality. The Show buttons and topic chips let each kind of visitor find their own path through the same material, and the tiles mix images, summaries, and full-text pages.

AI Use Statement

I used Claude (Anthropic) for site structure, code, publishing, and first drafts of copywriting, across one long working session from October 25 to 27, 2026. Unlike my static page, I let Claude write the code this time: the layouts, the filter script, and the stylesheet. I gave Claude push access to my repository, and it pushed changes only after I approved them. Claude also checked my writing samples word for word against my original files and flagged every difference before anything went online.

Claude suggested	**My decision**	**Why**
A black, Star Trek-style LCARS theme with sound effects	Rejected	Hard to read, and the novelty wore off fast
A white tile grid with a six-band pride stripe	Accepted	ChatGPT’s design critique pointed the same way
First drafts of my About Me bio	Rejected	They did not sound like me; I wrote my own lines
“First-year composition” as a class I teach	Rejected	I teach a sophomore writing and rhetoric course
A teaching philosophy trimmed from an AI-generated draft I pasted in	Modified	I cut the theory names and explained the ideas in plain words
Air, an MA thesis excerpt, and a tech comm piece as samples	Accepted	They show my teaching, research, and technical communication
The Bangkok section of my thesis over the Cutie Pie section	Accepted	It needs no setup and sounds most like me
Fixing typos in the thesis excerpt	Accepted	I approved each fix
A Bloomberg article to replace a citation my thesis never listed	Accepted	My original source was missing from the Works Cited
Rewording seven details in the grant toolkit and removing its QR code	Accepted	They could identify the nonprofit

Claude suggested	My decision	Why
A rocket instead of the Enterprise for the Star Trek tile	Rejected	That call was mine to make
An “Academia” topic chip	Modified	“University Life” means more to friends and family
“Life & Teaching” and “Research & Writing” as page subtitles	Accepted	Plainer than my “Personal & Pedagogy”
“Abstracts” as the label for my class papers	Rejected	My idea: “Coursework,” since class papers are not abstracts of finished articles
Show buttons only on the Portfolio page	Modified	My idea: every page longer than one scroll gets them

I used ChatGPT (OpenAI) on October 26 and 27, 2026, for images. For the About Me banner, I gave it my own photographs and asked for a composite built only by cropping, resizing, and arranging my actual photo pixels, retouching only “if it can be done without regenerating or reshaping my face.” Some early versions still changed my face, so I switched approaches: I had it pick 7 to 12 of my photos and use them without changes, then edit three photos one at a time and drop each approved photo into the collage.

For the dog photos, the owners allowed only cropping and color correction. My final prompt was:

> “Build the two 2400-pixel-wide, text-free dog strips from my original uploaded photographs only, using Goose G2 and Parker P2. Cropping, resizing, and gentle color correction only. Preserve each dog’s actual face and ears. Provide downloadable JPGs.”

For the thumbnails, ChatGPT turned Claude’s list of ideas into image instructions, generated 38 thumbnails, and revised six on October 27 after my feedback. It also researched Puerto Rican LGBTQ+ Pride flag designs for the Mundo Cruel thumbnail, and it converted, resized, and renamed the files. In separate chats, ChatGPT critiqued my button designs. ChatGPT did not review my site or this memo against the assignment.

ChatGPT produced	My decision	Why
New, regenerated versions of my photos for the About Me banner	Rejected	Some changed my facial features and the religious imagery in the photos
A collage of 7 to 12 of my photos, used without changes	Accepted	It kept my actual face

ChatGPT produced	My decision	Why
Single-photo edits for squinting, complexion, powdered-looking skin, and haze	Accepted	I approved each one before it went into the collage
Early dog composites	Rejected	The owners allowed only cropping and color correction
38 portfolio thumbnails	Accepted 31; redid 6; cut 1	Six did not fit their papers; I removed the book review entry entirely
Two versions of the Die Hard Bingo and Star Trek thumbnails	Chose one each	I picked the red bingo card and the Enterprise

I checked every written text on the site and certify its authenticity.